Sungmin Cho, professor at the Daniel K. Inouye Asia Pacific Center for Security Studies in Hawaii, during the early days of the Covid-19 crisis ordinary Chinese were quite openly critical of their central government. They soon split their view, turning their ire against local and provincial officials and voicing increasing support for Beijing and Xi. As the pandemic unfolded, Xi's popularity rose to unprecedented levels.[24] A survey by the Canadian researcher Cary Wu of nearly 20,000 Chinese in thirty-one provinces showed that 81–89 per cent of those surveyed were satisfied with the central government's performance in disseminating relevant information and making available daily necessities and protective gear.[25] At least part of this is attributable to China's relative success in handling the pandemic compared to the disastrous response of the West (as well as Brazil, India, and Russia). Cho argues, though, that the more telling fact is that ordinary Chinese including the youth are 'liberal nationalists' – liberal in holding local and provincial leaders to account and nationalists in defending China and the central government against any foreign criticism.[26] This suggests systemic strength not fragility – a 'safety valve' at the local and provincial levels where citizen dissatisfaction is vented, and a 'lid' at the central government level that will not permit dissent beyond a point.

Beyond the snapshot of Chinese views at a time of crisis, what is the long-term prognosis on internal stability? To get a better sense of the government's ability to handle serious internal troubles, the crucial issue is the attitude of ordinary Chinese people in the densely populated parts of the country. The future of communist party rule and internal stability is not so much related to what happens in Hong Kong, Tibet, and Xinjiang, which are in the periphery; it is the attitude of the population in the heartland areas that counts.

To get a sense of those attitudes, let us look at the trend in popular protests. Official figures show that between 1993 and 2004 so-called mass incidents rose from 8700 to 74,000. An unofficial estimate is that between 1993 and 2010 'protests' grew from about 10,000 to 180,000.[27] Another unofficial estimate, for a slightly later period, is that between June 2013 and June 2016 the total number of protests was nearly 75,000.[28] Clearly,